OFFERING CHOICES

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Young children often seem like they want to "be the boss"

- They are hard-wired to explore the world and figure out how it works through trial and error
- When they act like they want control of everything, they are just trying to discover where the limits and boundaries are. If there are no limits, the world can feel like a scary and unpredictable place
- Providing consistent limits and routines with opportunities for age-appropriate choices is a way to balance these needs:





Giving them opportunities to act like a "big kid" or "grown up" helps channel the need for independence and build self esteem

Offering choices about small things can also decrease meltdowns about things they can't choose, like routines

OFFERING CHOICES

Give them small choices that don't matter to you

- Examples include: which pajamas to wear, if they want to brush their teeth or go to the bathroom first, which snack they would like to have
- Offer two specific choices that are feasible for you
  - "Would you like to wear your red or blue pajamas tonight?"
- If you get pushback, validate their feelings and redirect to the choices you offered
  - "I hear that you want your yellow pajamas, but they are dirty and need to be washed. Would you like your red or blue pajamas tonight?"
- If they make a choice, praise them!
- If they don't make a choice: "It seems too hard to make a choice between the red and blue pajamas tonight. I'll choose for you tonight, and you will have the chance to choose again tomorrow"





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OFFERING CHOICES

Don't give them big choices or choices about things that you care about

Examples include:

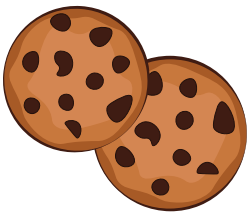
Whether they go to daycare/school that day

When to start the bedtime routine

Having chips and cookies for dinner







OFFERING CHOICES

It is the adult's job to maintain the routine

- Don't threaten to take away something that you can't follow through on or would feel resentful about giving up
  - If you make empty threats, you child will be less likely to take you seriously in the future and leads to more frustration
  - If you take away something that also affects you (e.g., your child's screen time, leaving a special event early), you may experience more frustration as well





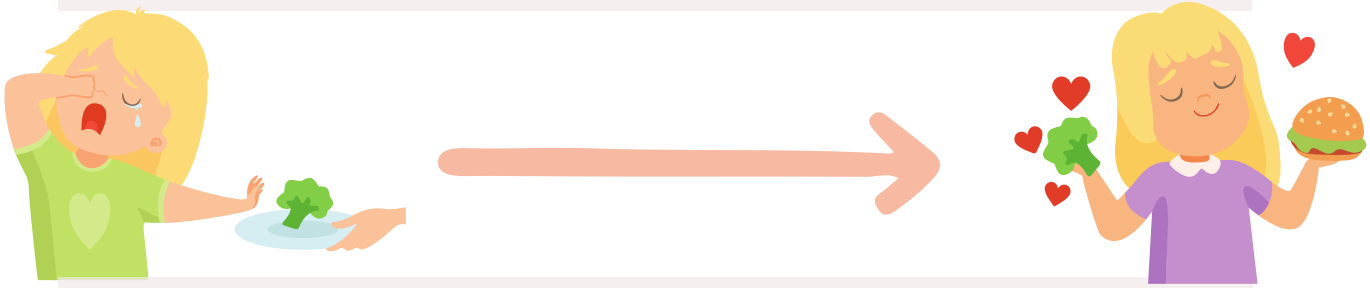
OFFERING CHOICES



EXAMPLE: PICKY EATING

Most young children go through a picky eating stage. It is usually not concerning as long as they continue to grow and gain weight

- Children learn to like new foods by being exposed to them many times
  - They won't eat a new food at first, which is ok. Continuing to offer it to them can help them become more open to the food over time



EXAMPLE: PICKY EATING

You choose which foods are on your child's plate, they decide what they eat

- Offer choices within a particular food group if it is feasible for you (e.g., strawberries or orange slices)
  - Don't force them to eat all the foods on their plate
- Offer a "no thank you" plate that kids can move foods to that they do not want to eat
  - Touching foods they don't want to eat is progress towards becoming more comfortable with the new food
  - Avoids battles at mealtimes and can help reduce food waste





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